

GroupSync — Prototype Description

Luna · BTE 646 · Product Management in the Digital Age · Prof. Henfridsson · April 5, 2026

Problem & User Insight

Every friend group has a "Bea" — the one who ends up organizing plans in the group chat, either because she needs to feel in control or because her friends just assign her the role. Either way, it's a chore. Scheduling alone eats 30+ messages, nobody agrees on what to do, and by the time something's picked, nobody's checked deals or budget fit. The planner burns out, the group hits decision fatigue, and half the time everyone defaults to "nvm I'll just stay in."

The insight — grounded in customer-problem fit thinking from Week 2 — is that the information needed to make a plan *already exists in the conversation*. People say when they're free, what they're craving, what they can afford. Nobody's synthesizing it. The job-to-be-done isn't "create a poll" — it's "resolve group indecision without killing the vibe."

Core Idea

GroupSync is an AI-powered chat extension for WhatsApp/iMessage. Only the planner installs it — it adds a widget inside her messaging app. The AI reads group chat context (dates, budget signals, cravings) and pre-populates a three-stage funnel:

When (availability poll) → **What** (swipe-to-vote on activity type) → **Where** (smart suggestions with real-time deals, dropped right into the chat). Everyone else participates inline. No downloads, no signups.

Doodle does scheduling. Yelp does recommendations. Groupon does deals. Nothing ties all three together where the conversation already happens — and nothing starts from what the group is already saying.

User Flow

- Group chat triggers planning → Bea taps the GroupSync widget
- AI parses chat context → surfaces date conflicts, budget signals, activity cues
- Availability poll goes out inline → group taps to vote on dates
- Swipe cards for activity types (food, drinks, adventure) → group votes
- Winning activity triggers location suggestions with real-time deals in chat → plan confirmed

Key Features & Differentiators

- **AI grounded in chat context** — reads preferences, budget cues, and scheduling signals from the actual conversation. Follows recognition-over-recall (Nielsen H6) by pre-populating options instead of starting from scratch.
- **Chat-native** — only the planner installs; everyone else participates inline. Aligns with consistency & standards / Jakob's Law (H4) by staying inside familiar platforms.
- **Real-time deal surfacing** tied to the chosen activity, day, and location.
- **Swipe-based voting** — fast, fun, low-friction. Aesthetic minimalism (H8): "communicate, don't decorate."

Feasibility & Next Steps

- MVP on one platform (WhatsApp Business/Extensions API) — manual availability poll + curated suggestions first, AI context parsing layered in after validating core engagement.
- Test with 5–10 real friend groups. Run a heuristic evaluation using the 4-step process from class (assemble evaluators, document independently, consolidate). A/B test swipe voting vs. traditional polls.
- Partner with one deals aggregator for proof of concept.

AI Tool Reflection

I used Claude (claude.ai) for concept development, writing, and generating the first HTML prototype (V1), then prompted Replit's AI agent with a detailed spec to build a second version (V2). V2 became the go-to — it handled interaction design better, especially the drag-to-swipe cards and deal banner. Where AI struggled: both tools defaulted to a standalone app concept, and I had to push the chat-native widget architecture myself. The AI also over-polished copy — I stripped inflated language to keep the tone grounded.